Sacrifice

By Joyce Carol Oates

MURIEL: Can you imagine?-bragging to my own brother Ray he's gonna do such things! To me! to me, he's married to, has kids with! Not even ashamed or anything! CAN YOU IMAGINE! *(A pause)* Oh sure I got a lawyer-in self-defense. Now he's got one too! *(Deep shuddering breath)* And all we owe-!

MURIEL pauses. Moves closer to audience. A sly, hectic, determined smile as she draws a knife out of a pocket-a sharply honed twelve-inch steak knife with a gleaming blade.

MURIEL: *(Whispering, wild-eyed)* You think I can't do it, huh? You just watch. *(Laughs)*

MURIEL contemplates the knife, testing possible grips-overhand, underhand. MURIEL hides the knife again.

INTRODUCTION

Coping with divorce - whether you've been through one or witnessed one -- is difficult, and often, downright ugly. Divorce causes people to say and do things that would normally be out of the realm of possibility. It sometimes causes people to do the unthinkable and unacceptable. It is a territorial battle where both people lose to some degree. It is a battle that causes casualties. The decision is always a Sacrifice by Joyce Carol Oats.

MURIEL: *(As if pleading)* I've been Eddie Fitzroy's wife for nine years and-now what? *(A pause)* Back to-what? My parents' house? My old room? Like I never had any kids, never been-loved? *(Fierce)* Well, I sure got kids. And all this, here- *(A wave of her hand, indicating her home, property)* -maybe the bank owns it but I'm sure here, and any son of a bitch wants me out is gonna have to carry me out. *(Incensed)* Had to get a lawyer, to protect myself-his lawyer's saying he can file for bankruptcy, so I get-nothing. No place to live no alimony no child support, maybe-can you believe it? *(Wiping face with a tissue)* Eddie Fitzroy, that everybody likes so much. 'Cause he's good-looking and was a quarterback

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for Ashland High and grins a lot, laughs easy-the bastard. Nine years.*(Grimmer, calmer, "fatalistic" tone)* You see it on TV all the time-women rising up against their oppressors. Oh, yes! *(A pause)*

MURIEL: *(Distractedly)* Saying he loved me-us-so much. Well-I know for a fact he did. All those years he did. I started putting on weight when I had Dwayne, he never minded-I'd swear. I minded more, going on one diet after another and making myself sick and Eddie would hug me and say, You look real nice to me, Muriel. Was he lying? HE WAS NOT LYING. I swear. *(Angry smile)* This, what I'm gonna do-strike to the heart!- (She pats the knife in her pocket) -is no rash crazy-lady act. No sir it's "premeditated." Oh yes! *(Laughs)* I got my defense all prepared-"PREMEN-STRUAL-TEN-SION-SYN-DROME"-you hear about it all the time. Even in the Pennysaver Shopping News. *(Laughs)* I read this article, underlined it, memorized it, threw it out-you bet I'm not that stupid, keeping it on the premises for the police to find.

MURIEL: *(Sudden anger)* "Gonna take Muriel to the cleaners"-huh? Can you believe it? Just 'cause he's out of work he don't give a shit for his own kids can you believe it! I'm just so ashamed, what am I s'posed to do, wear a paper bag over my head?-the rest of my life here in Ashland where I was born same as him God damn him! *(A pause)* A man like that, he loved his wife so, he near-about fainted when I was in labor, both times-like, like he was in labor. And that was no joke, either. He was.

MURIEL: *(Softer tone)* He was that way with the kids, too. He'd hug them sometimes squeezing the breath out of them, hurting them so they'd get scared. They'd think Daddy was playing but Daddy wasn't. "I love you honey, I love you"-he'd say to Dwayne, and to Junie. I'd hear him. Like it was some kind of prayer. *(A pause)* I guess you'd have to say he was a good father, sort of a nervous

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father but a good one, up till maybe a year ago. *(Wistful smile)* Maybe they all are-menfathers-real nice-up to the day when they're not.

MURIEL speaks passionately, as if the profound mystery at the heart of her experience is something that must be communicated, yet cannot be; she has lost the edge of her aggression and rage, and speaks almost reverently.

MURIEL: So-one day-one night-a few years ago-I'd gained maybe thirty pounds by then-we were in bed and, with Eddie, it was like always, him holding me so tight, except this time he really hurt me- and I panicked and shoved him away, I put on the light and looked at him, "Are you crazy," I said, my teeth were chattering I was so scared, "-what is it?" and Eddie's staring at me like he doesn't know me, this look on his face like he's a wild man or something, so now I was scared. *(A pause)* "Honey," I said, "-better tell me: what is it?" *(A pause, then, breathless)* So he told me. (A pause) You won't believe what he told me!

FLASHBACK

EDDIE: This cousin of mine, Bobbie-he was five years old when it happened. I was nine, and he was five. It was an accident, him drowning-that terrible way. But my fault. *(A pause)* We had these sleds-both of us, new sleds-Christmas sleds--and Bobbie broke through the ice and *(Breathless, speaking too rapidly, EDDIE must stop and try again).* Bobbie was. . . a nice kid. *(A pause. Stares at his hands, flexes his fingers)* It's hard to talk. I hate talking. Any kind of serious talk. You can't do it, so why try. *(Tries to control himself)* O.K., there was this big long hill--cow pasture-we'd sled down-to the creek. We took our sleds down the hill but we weren't supposed to go out on the creek even when it was frozen because, in the middle, sometimes, the ice was thin. I'd take my sled out,

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though, and Bobbie didn't tell on me, he was scared, watching me sled out onto the ice then steer to the side, quick, before the ice cracked. *(Dreamily, as if sledding, steering; a look of rapt, childish concentration)* There was a feeling I'd get if the ice was thin, here- *(He indicates the pit of his belly, scrotum)*-so I'd know. One day I was teasing Bobbie, I guess, and he followed me out onto the ice, but instead of steering to the side like I did he went straight out and right away the ice started cracking and he was screaming and his sled broke through, he was in the water, screaming, this freezing water that's black, and running fast-and I grabbed hold of him by the arm-got down on my stomach on the ice to try to keep it from breaking more-but I couldn't pull him out he was screaming, "Don't let me go! Don't let me go!"-Jesus, I'll remember it all my life. *(A pause)* He tried to grab onto me too, and pull himself out of the water, but he couldn't, and I couldn't get him out, the ice was breaking, the water was pulling him away, I don't know how long I had hold of him, by the wrist-ten minutes? five?-till my fingers froze and I just... had. . . to . . . let. . . him. . . go. *(A pause) (Self-loathing)* He was screaming, he didn't want to die. There was nobody but me to save him, nobody in the whole world but me, a nine-year-old kid, and. . . I had to let him go. *(A pause)* So he died, he drowned. I saw him go. I could see his body go. *(A pause) (Trying to be matter-of-fact)* Well-that was it. Bobbie died, aged five; I was to blame. All the years I was growing up I'd hear him screaming. I hear him now-it's always there. *(A distant look) (Half-sobbing)* I let him go. I couldn't save him.

MURIEL: *(Embracing him)* It wasn't your fault! I never knew, that poor little boy, but it wasn't your fault, Eddie, you were such a little boy yourself.

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EDDIE: I-I guess it comes over me, sometimes. I sort of black out. I don't know where I am. *(Dazedly, blinking)* Except-there's you. *(Pleading, as if for forgiveness)* Muriel, I love you so much. I love you so much. I want to take care of you, you and the kids, forever and ever I'd give my life for you, I love you so. You believe me, don't you? You love me, don't you? Muriel? I swear to God I won't let you go, I won't let you go, Muriel, all my life I'll take care of you, I'll show you-you and the kids. Jesus, I love you so much.

[Pause as flashback fades and the mood is immediately shattered.]

MURIEL: *(Desperate, flurried, appealing to audience)* You heard him! his exact words!-"All my life I'll take care of you!" You heard him! You heard him! You heard him! The liar! I know we had some hard times together lately. Buying things on credit-both of us to blame. Then, other things,-"marital problems." *(Embarrassed, tries for brazen cheerfulness)* Well, we all have them, huh?-"marital problems." You're married, that's what you have. Don't we? *(Peering at audience; a pause)* We'd been seeing a marriage counselor. So, yeah, I thought things were looking hopeful. Then, one day, instead of sitting down for supper, he looks at me, his face gets all funny, his eyes, and he says he can't do it,-so I say, "Can't do what?" and he says, "I want out, Muriel, I can't hack it, I want out-"

MURIEL: *(To audience, childlike pleading)* Y'know what I wish?-we could go on trial, that's what I wish! Him, and me! "A jury of one's peers!" *(A gesture at the audience)* Then justice would be done! *(Hugging herself tightly)* I read the Bible, now. I'm a sinful woman but I mean to exact justice. This morning, so early! I opened my Bible my grandma gave me-first words I read were-

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(MURIEL shuts her eyes, lets her head fall back, an expression of ecstasy on her face) Psalm 68: "Let God arise, let his enemies be scattered: let them also that hate them flee before him." *In her ecstatic trance, MURIEL draws the knife out of her pocket. Caresses it.* "PRE-MED-I-TATED"-"PRE-MEN-STRUAL." (Laughs) The jury can decide who's the murderer! *MURIEL, hiding the knife in the folds of her clothing, or behind her thigh, confronts EDDIE*

MURIEL: *(Surprisingly soft, pleading, girlish tone)* Eddie, hon-wait. The school bus will be here in twenty minutes. The kids

EDDIE: *(Guiltily)* I can't.

As EDDIE tries to ease away, MURIEL clutches his shirtsleeve.

MURIEL: Eddie, I love you-how'm I gonna live without you?

EDDIE: Christ, Muriel, you're making it so hard

MURIEL: *(Sobbing)* Eddie, honey, I'll lose weight-I will! I'll look like I used to! I'll go back to work! I won't bug you about things! Dwayne and Junie, they'll be good-they promised! Wait and see them, they'll tell you themselves

EDDIE: (Sweating, desperate to escape) Muriel, let me go, huh? Muriel, for God's sake LET ME GO!

MURIEL: *(Raw, unmitigated yearning)* I LOVE YOU-HOW CAN I "LET YOU GO!" *MURIEL crouches, cunning, feet apart, and brings around the knife-gripping it underhand so that, if she swings it, the upward arc will bring its blade into EDDIE'S abdomen.* You think I can't? You think I can't? You think I can't? *MURIEL feints with the knife.* We're better off dead, both of us.

EDDIE: Muriel, don't talk that way. Hon, listen (Wild laugh) What if the kids see you! Jesus!

MURIEL: *(Panting)* Let them! I want them to! I'll go on trial! I'm not ashamed! Promised you'd take care of us all your life-never let us go like you let your little cousin go-Murderer! That little boy you let drown, you liar, stinking hypocrite

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EDDIE: *(Angrily)* Bobbie's got nothing to do with you!

MURIEL: How can you let me go, after all that? *A tense pause.*

EDDIE: *(An outburst)* Because-I don't love you any more. *There is another tense pause. MURIEL realizes it is hopeless; she lowers the knife.*

MURIEL: *(Sudden flat, ironic tone)* Then-get the hell out, mister. *She gestures with the knife, waving him away MURIEL stares after him. Just when we think that MURIEL is resigned, she loses control; stabs the floor with the knife, sobbing.* Ugly thing, Muriel!-poor sad cow, Muriel! Take that, Muriel! Die!

SCENE BREAK

MURIEL: *(As if confiding in a woman friend)* So, well! That's that. *(Laughs, embarrassed)* Muriel tried. Muriel sure did. I lost three pounds this week-that's a start. *(A pause)* I guess my weakness is-I know right from wrong. My parents taught me to be good. *(Shrugs)* Probably couldn't stab Hitler, if he was standing in front of me. If that's goodness or just weakness, I don't know. One thing I know-you can't hurt another person to fix up your own life. Except, hell-I'd've liked a jury-"one's own peers." So you could explain it to me. Explain Eddie to me. How a man loves you, and the love wears out. How you love him-and that passes too. Like the black water's carrying us all away? Is that it? *(A pause)* Maybe you can explain it . . . ? I'm just trying to understand.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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